

Wednesday, 22 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Overcast

27° 19°

BIRMINGHAM

Overcast

26° 14°

MANCHESTER

Overcast

25° 15°

GLASGOW

Overcast

23° 14°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1

Fire crews are still tackling 'significant hot spots' at a huge wildfire in the Cairngorms, which has now been burning for over a week.

The blaze has scorched around 10 square kilometres of land in the Scottish Highlands. Firefighters are working tirelessly to bring it under control, but it's proving to be a persistent challenge.

ENVIRONMENT · UK

2

Lenders to Thames Water are reportedly offering the government a 'golden share' in the company, in a bid to prevent nationalisation.

The struggling water supplier has been facing major financial difficulties, leading to speculation it could be taken into public ownership. This eleventh-hour offer is an attempt to keep it in private hands.

BUSINESS · UK

3

The UK borrowed less than expected last month, according to new figures, but the nation's public finances are still facing a real challenge.

While June's borrowing was better than forecast, the overall picture shows the UK is still carrying a significant amount of debt. It's a constant balancing act for the Treasury.

ECONOMY · UK

4

Two teenagers have been jailed for the murder of 16-year-old Kayden Moy, who was killed in a knife attack on a Scottish beach.

Kayden was fatally wounded during a confrontation on Irvine Beach in North Ayrshire last May. It's a tragic reminder of the devastating impact of knife crime.

CRIME · UK

5

The Metropolitan Police are investigating the death of a man who fell from a balcony after railings gave way as he checked on a pizza delivery.

Joshua Robbins tragically fell to his death after the incident. A coroner has been told that police are now looking into the circumstances surrounding what happened.

ACCIDENT · UK

What's coming up

1 **Get ready for some serious muscle on your screens, as former World's Strongest Man Tom Stoltman is set to join the cast of Gladiators!**

The 32-year-old, 6ft 8in athlete from the Highlands will be one of the new Gladiators in the fourth series of the popular Saturday night show. He's certainly going to be a formidable presence!

ON AIR – Who do you think would make a great new Gladiator?

TV · FORTHCOMING

2 **A former Blue Peter presenter has stunned the judges on America's Got Talent with his incredible magic skills!**

Joel M wowed the panel by making their personal items disappear during his audition on the latest series. It sounds like he's going to be one to watch across the pond!

ON AIR – What's the most impressive magic trick you've ever seen?

TV · FORTHCOMING

3 **Imagine taking a Beatles tour in Liverpool, only to pull up next to Sir Paul McCartney himself at the traffic lights!**

That's exactly what happened to some lucky fans, who were thrilled to spot the music legend. What an incredible moment for those on board!

ON AIR – Have you ever had a chance encounter with a famous musician?

MUSIC · CURRENT

4 **Meet the barber behind some of football's most famous cuts – Ahmed Alsanawi, better known as A-Star, who styles the England World Cup squad!**

He's the man trusted by the Three Lions to keep them looking sharp on the pitch. It seems a good haircut is just as important as a good game plan!

ON AIR – Do you think a fresh haircut can give you an edge?

CELEBRITY · CURRENT

5 **An 85-year-old woman is living in her very own art installation, after a fascinating career that included being a TV chef!**

Sue Kreitzman, who was also a teacher and cookbook author, has truly embraced a unique artistic path. It sounds like her home is a feast for the eyes!

ON AIR – What's the most unusual home decor you've ever seen?

ART · CURRENT

On the schedule

1 **A consortium led by British-Indian millionaire Amit Bhatia is reportedly in talks to buy a minority stake in Liverpool FC.**

The news suggests potential new investment for the Premier League club. It'll be interesting to see how these discussions progress and what it could mean for the Reds.

ON AIR – What's the biggest change you've seen at your favourite football club?

FOOTBALL · UK

2 **Long-serving Premier League referee Anthony Taylor has announced his immediate retirement from refereeing, ending a 20-year career.**

Taylor cited the 'intense pressure and constant scrutiny' of the role as reasons for stepping away. It's a demanding job, and he's certainly had a long and distinguished career.

ON AIR – Do you think referees get enough credit for the job they do?

FOOTBALL · UK

3 **Aston Villa are reportedly in talks to sign Chelsea winger Alejandro Garnacho on loan, with a potential obligation to buy.**

It could be a significant move for both clubs as the transfer window heats up. Villa will be hoping to bolster their squad with the talented youngster.

ON AIR – Which transfer rumour are you most excited about right now?

FOOTBALL · UK

4 **World number two Luke Humphries has suffered a shock first-round exit at the World Matchplay darts tournament!**

Humphries was beaten by Scotland's Cameron Menzies in a major upset. It just goes to show that in darts, anything can happen on the day!

ON AIR – What's your favourite sport to watch for an unexpected upset?

DARTS · UK

5 **Newcastle United supporters are set to vote on a new club crest, as the club looks to change its badge for the first time since 1988.**

It's a big decision for the club and its loyal fanbase. A new badge could signal a new era for the Magpies.

ON AIR – Do you like it when your favourite team changes its badge or kit?

FOOTBALL · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A delightful trend has emerged: 'neighbourhood book swaps' are popping up in communities across the UK.**
People are setting up small, often decorated, outdoor boxes or shelves where locals can take a book and leave a book. It's a lovely way to share stories and connect with neighbours.
- 2 Research suggests that 'mindful dishwashing' can significantly reduce stress and enhance a sense of well-being.**
Focusing on the warmth of the water, the feel of the bubbles, and the scent of the soap turns a chore into a calming meditation. It's all about being present in the moment!
- 3 The simple joy of 'writing and sending postcards' is experiencing a charming renaissance among all ages.**
Instead of quick texts, many are opting for the personal touch of a handwritten message and a scenic stamp. It's a lovely way to keep in touch and share a little piece of your day.
- 4 Experts are noticing a rise in the popularity of 'stargazing gatherings' in rural areas and even city parks.**
Equipped with blankets and thermos flasks, people are meeting up to appreciate the night sky away from light pollution. It's a wonderful, peaceful way to spend an evening.
- 5 A new study indicates that simply 'watching fish in an aquarium' can lower blood pressure and heart rate.**
The gentle movement of the fish and the soothing aquatic environment provide a surprisingly effective form of relaxation. Perhaps it's time for a little fishy friend?
- 6 The delightful art of 'identifying local wildflowers' is becoming a popular pastime for nature enthusiasts.**
Armed with guidebooks and keen eyes, people are discovering the diverse and beautiful flora right on their doorsteps. It's a charming way to explore the British countryside.
- 7 There's a growing trend of 'community seed libraries' where gardeners can share and swap seeds.**
These local initiatives encourage biodiversity and help people grow a wider variety of plants. It's a wonderful way to foster a green-fingered community spirit.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to navigate somewhere new, even if we know it makes us look a bit lost?

ANSWER: TURNING DOWN THE RADIO TO 'SEE' BETTER.

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a piece of chocolate. What is it?

ANSWER: SNIFFING IT DEEPLY FIRST, JUST TO GET THE FULL AROMA EXPERIENCE!

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes a particular 'sound' just instantly makes you feel cosy and at home?**
It could be the gentle hum of the fridge, the distant sound of a train, or even the familiar creak of a floorboard. What's that one sound that just spells 'home' for you?

- **We all have those 'little everyday moments' that just make us smile, don't we?**
Perhaps it's spotting a particularly fluffy cloud, finding a perfectly ripe avocado, or getting a green light all the way through town. What's a recent small moment that brought a bit of unexpected cheer to your day?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Nature.** Did you know that flamingos get their pink colour from the food they eat? Their diet of brine shrimp and algae contains pigments called carotenoids, which are responsible for their vibrant hue.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** It's said that if you whisper a secret to a 'whispering willow' tree at midnight, the tree will carry your secret away on the wind, ensuring it's never heard by human ears.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£2 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£2 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The world's smallest fish, *Paedocypris progenetica*, is only about 8 millimetres long and lives in the peat swamps of Sumatra.
- Butterflies taste with their feet, using chemoreceptors to find host plants and nectar sources.
- The longest place name in the UK is Llanfairpwllgwyngyllgogerychwyrndrobwlllantysiliogogogoch, a village in Wales.
- A group of owls is called a parliament.
- The average person walks the equivalent of five times around the world in their lifetime.
- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are still edible.
- The first successful photograph was taken in 1826 by French inventor Joseph Nicéphore Niépce.
- The 'Big Ben' clock tower in London is officially named Elizabeth Tower, and Big Ben is actually the nickname for the great bell inside.

On this day

Day 203 of the year, 162 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abd-al-Masih; Christian feast day: Anna Wang; Christian feast day: Mary Magdalene; Christian feast day: Markella. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1996 — Skyler Gisondo, American actor
- 1953 — Brian Howe, English singer-songwriter (died 2020)
- 1954 — Lonette McKee, American actress and singer
- 1992 — Selena Gomez, American singer and actress
- 1941 — Estelle Bennett, American singer (died 2009)
- 1943 — Bobby Sherman, American singer-songwriter and actor (died 2025)
- 1947 — Albert Brooks, American actor, comedian, director, and screenwriter
- 1954 — Al Di Meola, American guitarist, songwriter, and producer

THE DAY TODAY

- 1990 — Greg LeMond, an American road racing cyclist, wins his third Tour de France after leading the majority of the race. It was LeMond's second consecutive Tour de France victory.
- 2003 — Iraq War: Members of 101st Airborne of the United States, aided by Special Forces, attack a compound in Iraq, killing Saddam Hussein's sons Uday and Qusay, along with Mustapha Hussein, Qusay's 14-year-old son, and a bodyguard.
- 1943 — World War II: Axis occupation forces violently disperse a massive protest in Athens, killing 22.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1951 — Soviet space dogs: Dezik and Tsygan were launched into a sub-orbital spaceflight from Kapustin Yar and became the first dogs to fly in space and the first to safely return.
- 1943 — World War II: Axis occupation forces violently disperse a massive protest in Athens, killing 22.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1983 — Martial law in Poland is officially revoked.
- 2005 — Jean Charles de Menezes is killed by police as the hunt begins for the London Bombers responsible for the 7 July 2005 London bombings and the 21 July 2005 London bombings.

- 1963 — Crown Colony of Sarawak gains self-governance.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 204 of the year, 161 days left in 2026. Today Birthday of Haile Selassie (Rastafari); Children's Day (Indonesia); Christian feast day: Blessed Basil Hopko; Christian feast day: Bridget of Sweden. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1961 — Martin Gore, English singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1965 — Slash, English-American guitarist, songwriter, and producer
- 1942 — Madeline Bell, American singer-songwriter
- 1984 — Celeste Thorson, American actress, producer, and screenwriter
- 1947 — David Essex, English singer-songwriter, and actor
- 1992 — Danny Ings, English footballer
- 1965 — Rob Dickinson, English singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1980 — Sandeep Parikh, American actor, director, producer, and screenwriter

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1982 — Outside Santa Clarita, California, actor Vic Morrow and two children are killed when a helicopter crashes onto them while shooting a scene from *Twilight Zone: The Movie*.
- 1992 — A Vatican commission, led by Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger, establishes that limiting certain rights of homosexual people and non-married couples is not equivalent to discrimination on grounds of race or gender.
- 1993 — China Northwest Airlines Flight 2119 crashes during takeoff from Yinchuan Xihuayuan Airport in Yinchuan, Ningxia, China, killing 55 people.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1988 — General Ne Win, effective ruler of Burma since 1962, resigns after pro-democracy protests.
- 1999 — Space Shuttle Columbia launches on STS-93, with Eileen Collins becoming the first female space shuttle commander. The shuttle also carried and deployed the Chandra X-ray Observatory.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026	
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)